

the church's brand new Cavaillé-Coll organ (see box). Franck soon became a virtuoso on this incredible instrument.

Congregations would linger after the service to listen to his improvisations. The organ company was so impressed by his skills that it hired him as an artistic consultant, which meant he could give recitals on other Cavaillé-Coll organs.

Franck was also a notable teacher, becoming professor of organ at the Paris Conservatoire in 1871, where he also informally taught composition to a group of faithful students known as the *bande à Franck*. His jobs left him little time for his own composition, and it was only after retirement that he saw the celebrity status his father had hoped for. The *Six Pièces* (1859–1862) is probably his finest organ work, while the *Variations Symphoniques* (1885) and the *Violin Sonata* (1886) are generally seen as his masterpieces.

“It was said of Franck that **the discovery** of a single **new chord** was sufficient to make him **happy** for a **whole day**.”

NORMAN DEMUTH, ENGLISH COMPOSER AND  
MUSICOLOGIST, 1951